

PASSWORD MANAGEMENT POLICY

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 Let's Innovate	IT POLICIES AND PROCEDURES		Document Number	I2I/ISMS/PMP
			Date	10/12/2024
			Revision No	1.0
			Page	1 of 6

Revision History

#	Version	Release Date	Description of the Change	Created/ Modified by	Approved by
1	1.0	16-Dec-2022	Initial	Kalpana J	Gayathri

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	IT POLICIES AND PROCEDURES		Document Number	I2I/ISMS/PMP
			Date	10/12/2024
			Revision No	1.0
			Page	2 of 6

Password Management Policy

1. Purpose The purpose of this Password Management Policy is to ensure that all passwords used to access the organization's systems, networks, and data are created, stored, and managed securely to protect against unauthorized access. The policy outlines requirements for the creation, use, storage, and protection of passwords to minimize the risk of security breaches.

2. Scope This policy applies to all employees, contractors, consultants, and other users who access the organization's information systems, including software applications, email accounts, databases, and any other systems requiring password authentication.

3. Password Creation Guidelines

- **Minimum Password Length:** All passwords must be at least **8 characters** in length, with a strong preference for passwords containing **12 characters** or more.
- **Password Complexity:** Passwords must contain a combination of:
 - Uppercase letters
 - Lowercase letters
 - Numbers
 - Special characters (e.g., @, #, \$, %, &, etc.)
- **Prohibited Passwords:** The use of easily guessable passwords such as "password123", "admin", the user's name, or common patterns (e.g., "qwerty", "123456") is strictly prohibited.
- **Avoid Personal Information:** Passwords must not contain personal information such as the user's name, date of birth, or any other easily accessible information.
- **Password Expiry:** Passwords must be changed every **90 days**. Users will receive reminders prior to expiration.

	IT POLICIES AND PROCEDURES		Document Number	I2I/ISMS/PMP
			Date	10/12/2024
			Revision No	1.0
			Page	3 of 6

4. Password Storage and Handling

- **Password Storage:** Passwords should never be stored in plain text. Instead, passwords must be hashed and encrypted using industry-standard methods (e.g., bcrypt, PBKDF2, etc.).
- **Password Management Tools:** Users are encouraged to use approved **password management tools** for storing and managing passwords securely. Examples of such tools include LastPass, 1Password, or Bitwarden.
- **Avoid Shared Passwords:** Password sharing between employees is strongly discouraged. If sharing is necessary (e.g., for system administration), temporary access or a shared vault in a password manager should be used.
- **No Writing Down Passwords:** Passwords should never be written down or stored in physical locations (e.g., sticky notes, notepads) that are easily accessible.

5. Authentication Requirements

- **Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA):** Multi-Factor Authentication must be enabled wherever possible, especially for accessing sensitive systems, data, and applications. MFA could involve something you know (password), something you have (OTP, security token), or something you are (biometric verification).
- **Unique User Accounts:** Every user must have a unique user account for accessing systems and applications. Shared accounts must be avoided, except where explicitly authorized for operational purposes.

6. Password Sharing and Transfer

- **Password Sharing:** Employees must not share their passwords with others. If password sharing is absolutely necessary for business purposes, it must be done through secure channels such as password management tools or encrypted communication.

	IT POLICIES AND PROCEDURES		Document Number	I2I/ISMS/PMP
			Date	10/12/2024
			Revision No	1.0
			Page	4 of 6

- **Password Transfer:** Passwords should not be sent via unsecured communication channels such as email or chat. Secure methods such as password managers or encrypted communication channels should be used.

7. User Responsibilities

- **Strong Password Practices:** Users must ensure that their passwords are unique and follow the organization's password guidelines. Employees should also avoid using the same password across different systems.
- **Prompt Reporting of Security Incidents:** If a user suspects that their password has been compromised, they should immediately report it to the IT or Security team and change their password.
- **Logout After Use:** Users should log out of systems and applications when they are no longer in use to prevent unauthorized access, especially on shared or public devices.

8. IT Team Responsibilities

- **Password Security Measures:** The IT team is responsible for implementing and enforcing password policies, ensuring that systems are configured to require secure password practices, and monitoring for potential violations.
- **Audit and Review:** The IT department will conduct regular audits of password usage and security compliance to ensure adherence to this policy. Unauthorized password access and violations will be investigated promptly.

9. Compliance and Enforcement

- **Non-Compliance:** Any employee found to be in violation of this policy may face disciplinary action, which could include revocation of access privileges, formal warnings, suspension, or termination, depending on the severity of the violation.

 Let's Innovate	IT POLICIES AND PROCEDURES	Document Number	I2I/ISMS/PMP
		Date	10/12/2024
		Revision No	1.0
		Page	5 of 6

- Compliance with Legal Requirements:** This policy aligns with applicable data protection regulations, including the **Information Technology (Reasonable Security Practices and Procedures and Sensitive Personal Data or Information) Rules, 2011** and any other relevant Indian laws.

10. Policy Review and Updates This Password Management Policy will be reviewed annually to ensure its effectiveness and relevance in light of evolving security threats and technological changes. Updates or amendments to the policy will be communicated to all employees.